SUPPLEMENTARY PORTFOLIO · PHOTOGRAPHY

Anwar Khan

Selected photographs, 2023–2025

Ten images · digital, 35mm film, and composite
Prospective mechanical engineering applicant

COVER: WIND-UP, 2024



A reason to stand still.

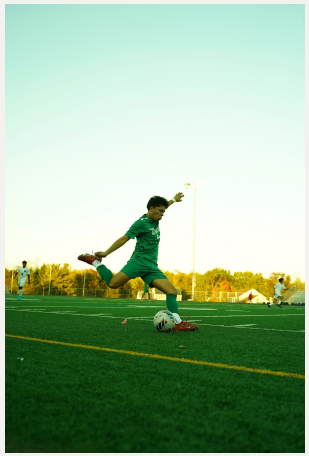
I started taking photos because I wanted to slow down. Most of what I do moves fast: soccer since I was four, sim racing on a wooden rig with a gaming chair, afternoons in the garage with my dad and his Supra. A camera is the one thing that makes me stand still.

What I look for in a frame is what I look for in a design: every line has a reason to be there. I'll spend too long at Lake Elkhorn waiting for one branch to sit right against the light. On film I get thirty-six chances, so I think harder about each one. On digital I take a hundred and cut hard.

These photos are of what I care about: cars, the game, and the places I pass on the way somewhere else. I want to study mechanical engineering, and photography is how I practice seeing: noticing where the weight of an image sits, and what happens when you move it an inch.

Anwar Khan

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2024



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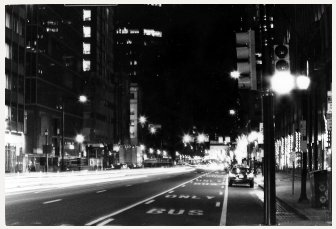
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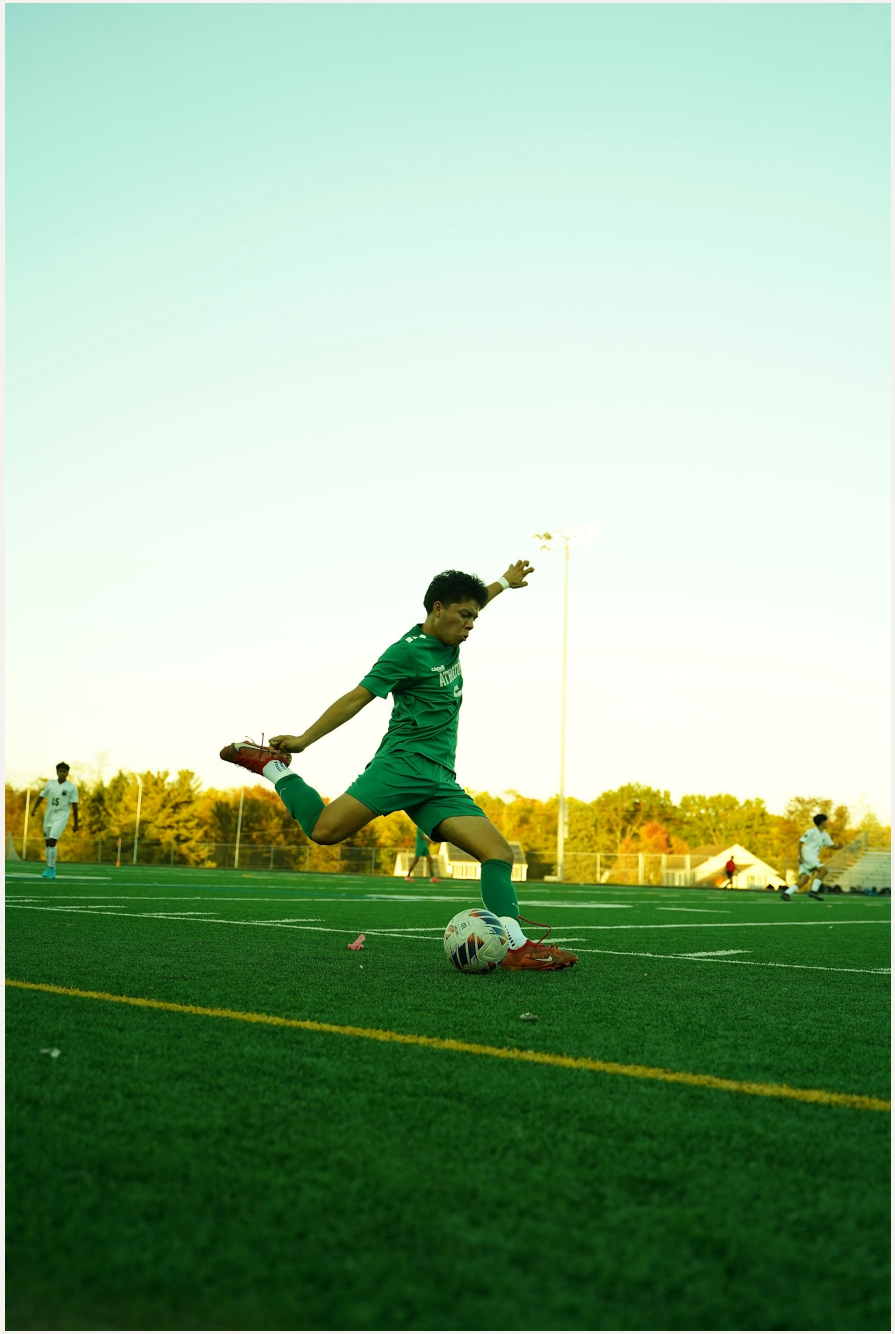
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01

Wind-Up

Digital photograph (Sony A7 III) · October 2024

My friend David loading up a strike, shot from turf level so the ball, the plant foot and the raised arm line up against an open evening sky.

I was injured for the season, so I spent it on the ground at the edge of the field instead of on it. For a while I hated being there. Watching a game you're supposed to be playing in is its own kind of injury. Bringing my camera changed that. Sitting on the turf put my lens at the exact height of the ball, and I started watching the game differently: not the play itself, but the half-second before it. This is David in that half-second. I didn't set it up. I had the camera raised, he planted his foot, and everything I'd been waiting on all afternoon lined up at once: the ball, the arm, the light behind him. It's the closest I came to playing that season, and it taught me that being sidelined doesn't mean you stop paying attention.



02

Glass Ascent

35mm black-and-white film, darkroom print · April 2025

Looking straight up a glass curtain wall near Bryant Park in New York, tilted until the mullions became a single set of converging lines.

Our Photo 2 class spent the day in Manhattan, and almost everyone was shooting at eye level: the crowds, the vendors, the park. I kept looking up. Midtown is built so you never see the whole of anything; the buildings are too tall and too close. This one was different, because the glass let me see through the structure to the sky behind it. On film there's no screen to check, so I stood on the sidewalk long enough for people to start walking around me, adjusting the angle until every line met where I wanted it to. I didn't know whether it worked until the print came up in the developer tray days later. That wait is a big part of why I love film: you have to commit to a decision before you know how it turns out, and then live with it.



03

Tidal Basin

Digital photograph (Sony A7 III) · March 2025

The Washington Monument rising over the Tidal Basin at peak bloom, with the water and the cherry trees layered beneath it.

My family and I went to see the cherry blossoms along with what felt like half the East Coast. On the path around the Tidal Basin we were shoulder to shoulder, and most of what I could see was the backs of people taking the same picture. I wandered toward the water's edge where the bank curves and found one angle where the crowd shrank to a thin line under the trees and the Monument stood clear above everything. My family kept walking, and I had to jog to catch back up with them. I like this photo because it holds both halves of that afternoon: the crowd is in it, but so is the quiet you could only find by stepping a few feet off the path. The best part of the day was still the people I came with; this is just the view I wanted to bring back to them.



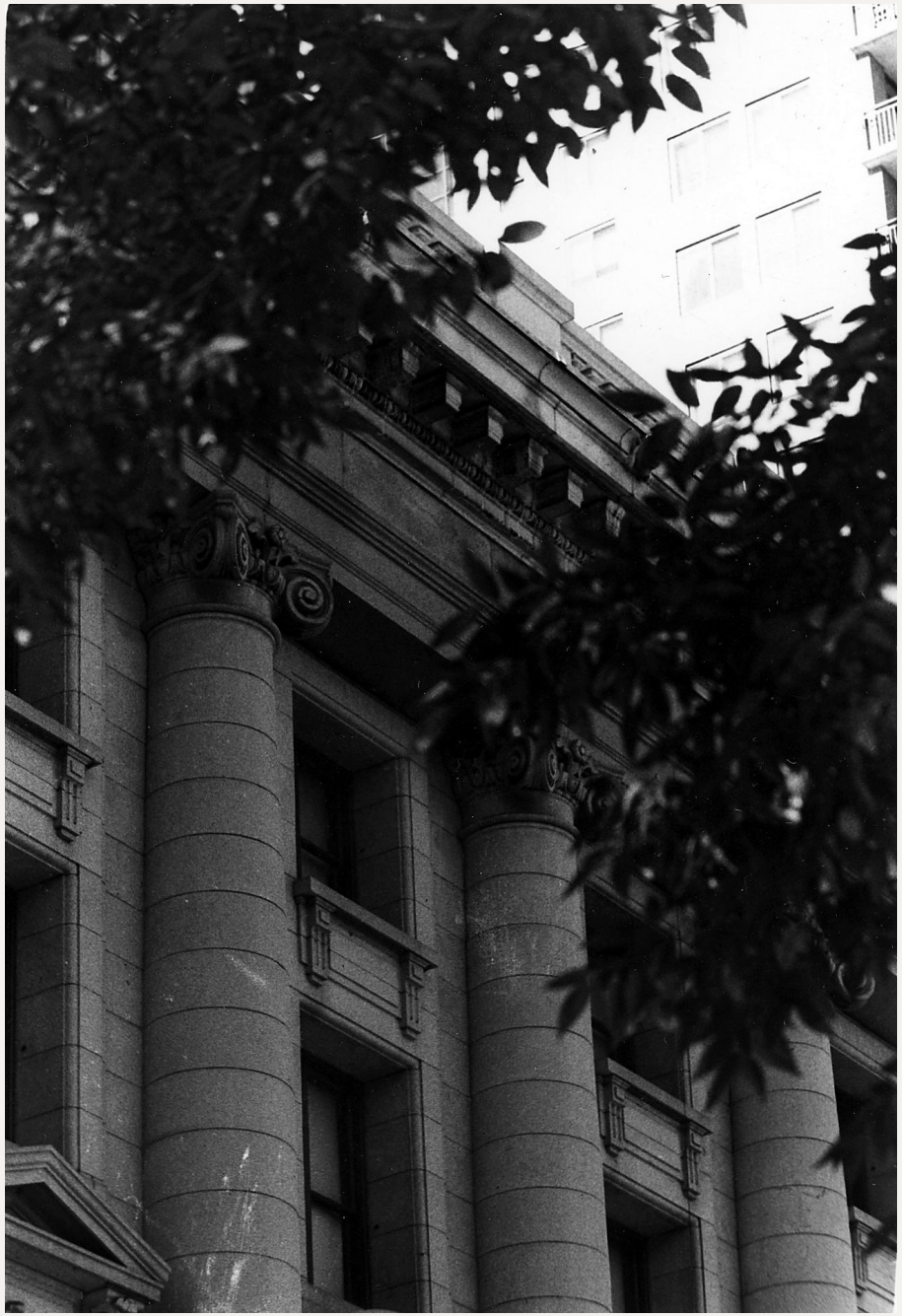
04

Parker

Digital photograph, desaturated, solarized and double-exposed in Photoshop · April 2025

My friend Parker in profile, grayed out, solarized and double-exposed with a landscape so the scenery fills the shape of his head.

I took this in the locker room before a game. I asked Parker if I could take his portrait and he refused to look at the camera. He stared off to the side the whole time, which annoyed me then and turned out to be the reason the picture works. A face tells you how to feel; a profile leaves room. At home I grayed the image out, solarized it so the tones flip at the edges, and double-exposed it with a landscape I'd shot. I went through a lot of scenery before I found one whose texture matched how he carries himself: steady, a little guarded, more going on inside than he lets on. It became my signature Photoshop piece. It started with a friend who wouldn't cooperate, and I've learned that the version of a photo you didn't plan is often the one worth keeping.



05

Between the Leaves

35mm black-and-white film, darkroom print

A stone facade in Washington, D.C., framed between two tree branches, with the carved capitals and the highlights on the stone set against dark leaves.

This is one of my favorite film photos. What drew me in was the stonework: every course of the columns, the scrolls of the capitals, the way the light catches the edges of the blocks and leaves everything else in shadow. In color it might just look like another government building. In black and white, the stone and the leaves become the same material, just light and dark, and the branches frame the facade like a window. Film gave this photo its texture; I can see the grain in the stone. What I keep coming back to is the contrast in time. The building was made to last a century or more. The leaves in front of it would be gone by November. For one frame they share the same space.



06

Loki

Digital photograph

My cat Loki at eye level, shot wide open so the room falls away and only his copper eyes stay sharp.

Loki is the most dramatic member of my family. Most of the time he is curled up asleep on a chair, but every so often he locks onto something and turns into this: completely still, completely focused, a panther that happens to live in our house. He can look intense, but I love his copper eyes. I shot this wide open so everything behind him melted away and nothing could compete with them. Getting a cat to hold still at eye level takes patience and a lot of treats, the same negotiation I go through to get him into the car for our walks down by the creek. He isn't an assignment or a project. He's someone I love, and I wanted one photo that shows him the way I see him.



07

Behind the Wheel

35mm black-and-white film, darkroom print

Hands on the wheel on a road trip south through the mountains, shot from the passenger seat in late-day light.

My dad and I drove from Maryland to Atlanta, and on the way down the road wound through the mountains. Somewhere along that stretch the light started coming in low through the windshield and lit up everything: the dash, the gauges, his hands on the wheel, and the hills sliding past outside. I grew up watching my dad drive, and working on his Supra next to him is how I learned to take things apart and put them back together. In the passenger seat with my film camera, I realized I wanted to remember the drive more than the destination. I only got a frame or two before the road turned and the light changed. It's the photo that feels most like him to me: steady hands, eyes on the road, and the patience to get somewhere the long way.



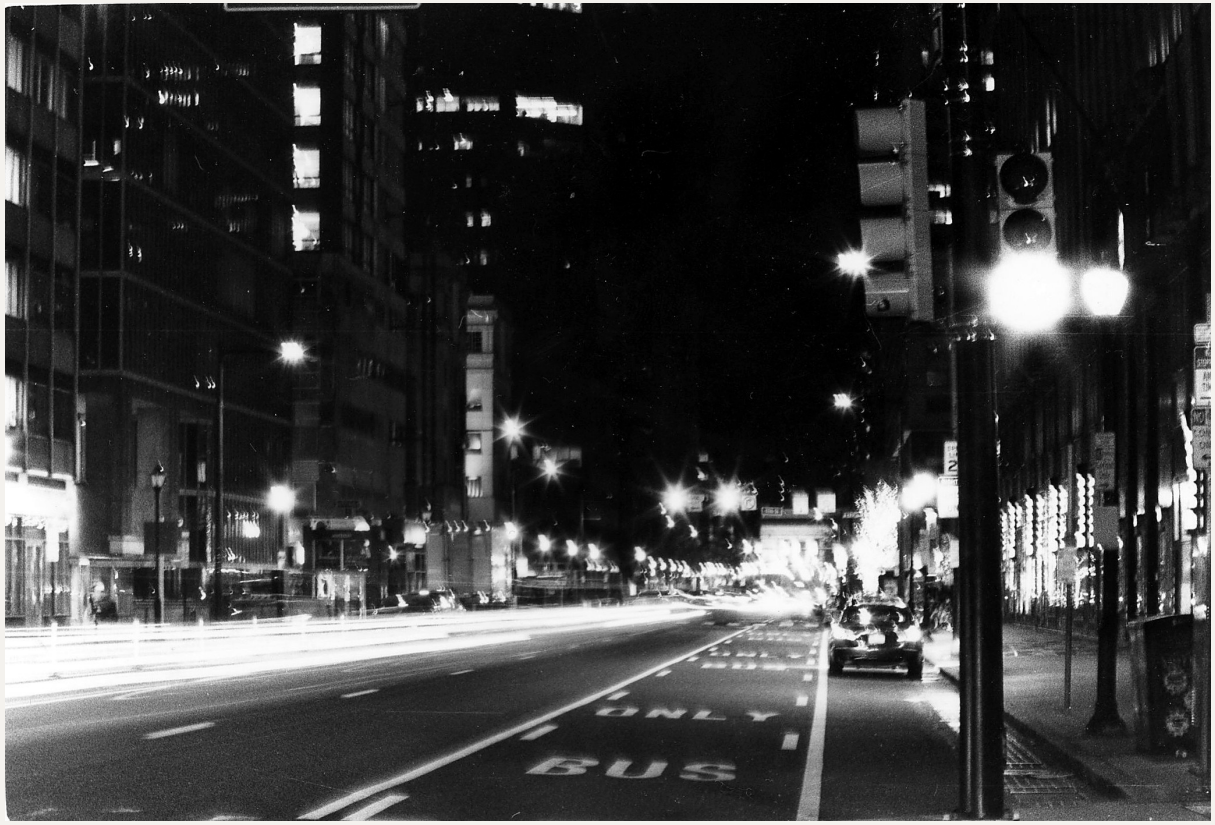
08

First Frame

Digital photograph (Sony A7 III), color print

Green leaves in my backyard catching the light, with the background thrown out of focus.

This is the first photo I ever took with my Sony A7 III. I saved up for it for a long time and begged my parents to contribute the rest. I wanted it for sports photography. My dad's old Canon DSLR couldn't reach a fast enough shutter speed or a clean enough ISO to freeze players at night, with the ball moving as fast as it does. A full-frame mirrorless camera could. The day it arrived I walked into the backyard and pointed it at the first thing the light was hitting: these leaves. The detail in the blades and the softness behind them were more than I had ever gotten out of a camera. It's a quiet photo for a camera I bought to shoot action, but it marks the moment my photography changed, from working around the limits of my equipment to having a tool that could keep up with what I was seeing.



09

Bus Only

35mm black-and-white film, darkroom print · March 2025

A long exposure on a downtown Philadelphia street at night: traffic smears into light while the buildings, signals and parked car hold still.

This was a blisteringly cold night in Philadelphia. I set up two tripods side by side on the sidewalk, one for my film camera and one for my digital. On digital I could check every attempt, and it still took me a long time, with frozen fingers adjusting shutter speed and aperture shot after shot, before the traffic smeared into clean lines while the buildings stayed sharp. Then I switched the lens over to the film body, dialed in the same settings, and took a frame I couldn't check. This is that frame. Getting it meant doing the slow work up front, testing and measuring and adjusting, and then trusting the numbers. It shows the difference between the two kinds of photography better than anything I could say, and it shows how I like to work: the digital camera is where I figure things out, and the film camera is where I commit.



10

Bayside Sunset

Digital photograph (iPhone 12) · July 2023

Two trees silhouetted against a golden-hour sunset over the Chesapeake Bay in North East, Maryland.

I took this freshman year, when I was just getting into photography. My cousins have a beach house in North East, on the Chesapeake, and I was walking down the road at golden hour when the trees lined up against the water. All I had was my phone, and I barely knew what I was doing, but I knew I wanted to keep it. Now this photo holds a lot more than a sunset. It brings back jet skiing with my cousins, barbecues and long dinners with my family and sometimes my friends, and night swimming down at the beach after dark. When I look at it I'm back on that road with the whole summer still ahead of me. It's the oldest photo in this portfolio, and in a way it's the reason the rest of them exist.